

Sauropods and relatives

These lumbering giants were the largest creatures ever to walk the Earth. Amazingly long necks let them reach far higher than other plant eaters could, making it possible to feed on treetops as giraffes do today. But they needed pillarlike limbs to support their immense weight, and, unlike most dinosaurs, they usually had to walk on all fours.

▲ **BRACHIOSAURUS**
used its spoon-shaped teeth to snip leaves from the tops of conifers, tree ferns, and other trees. It ate about 440 lb (200 kg) of leaves and twigs a day.

Brachiosaurus

brackee-oh-SORE-uss



- **When** 150–145 million years ago (Late Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 75 ft (23 m)
- **Diet** Treetop leaves and twigs of conifers

One of the largest sauropods, *Brachiosaurus* weighed an incredible 33–55 tons (30–50 metric tons)—nearly 12 times more than an African elephant. *Brachiosaurus*'s long neck helped it to feed at heights of more than 50 ft (15 m), which is twice as high as any giraffe can reach.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Small heads and large bodies
- Long, flexible necks
- Long, whiplike tails

When

Sauropods first appeared in the Late Triassic, almost 227 million years ago, and died out at the end of the Cretaceous, 65 million years ago.